



Your newborn may need **extra care** or medical attention before he can go home if he was born prematurely, or needs to be **monitored or treated** because of occurrences during his development, or the birth itself. This section looks at some **situations and conditions** that require special care, and the type of care your baby will receive.

Special-care babies

After the birth

If you had complications during pregnancy, or a problem with your baby was identified during prenatal screening, you may have been prepared for your baby to be taken care of by a medical team immediately after the birth. Your doctor should have explained what he or she will need to do before the birth, so you will know what to expect. You may also have had a chance to visit the neonatal intensive care unit (NICU) in the hospital and will be familiar with the facilities. If a problem wasn't anticipated, it can be a shock and extremely worrying if your baby needs medical attention at birth. The maternity staff may not have time to fully explain what is happening, because their priority will be your baby's health and well-being. As soon as possible, though, they will inform you about your baby's condition, and explain to you why your baby needs medical care.

Your role in the care of your special-care baby

Seeing your baby carried off and into the care of nurses feels totally counterintuitive for most parents—since the important first moments of parenthood are literally taken from your hands. However, even though your baby needs extra medical help, his emotional and psychological well-being relies upon you. He has been listening to your

voice from within your uterus, so talking to him, as well as caressing him and holding him whenever you can, make sure that his recovery is as rapid as it possibly can be.

Where special-care babies are taken care of

Many hospitals have a neonatal intensive care unit (NICU) where babies are taken when they need help after birth. Usually this unit has four divisions, each one providing a different level of care appropriate to the seriousness of a baby's condition. Occasionally, a hospital may be unable to provide the level of specialized care your baby requires, and in this case your baby may need to be transferred to a hospital with the right facilities.

» **Level I units** treat babies who were born between 35–37 weeks and need a little bit of extra care.

» **Level II units** treat babies older than 32 weeks who have breathing problems or other issues that are expected to resolve fairly quickly.

» **Level III units** provide life-sustaining care for newborns younger than 32 weeks and/or low-birthweight babies, and these units have pediatric specialists on hand in addition to neonatal specialists.

» **Level IIII units** can do all of these things, plus babies who need intensive surgery can get it here.